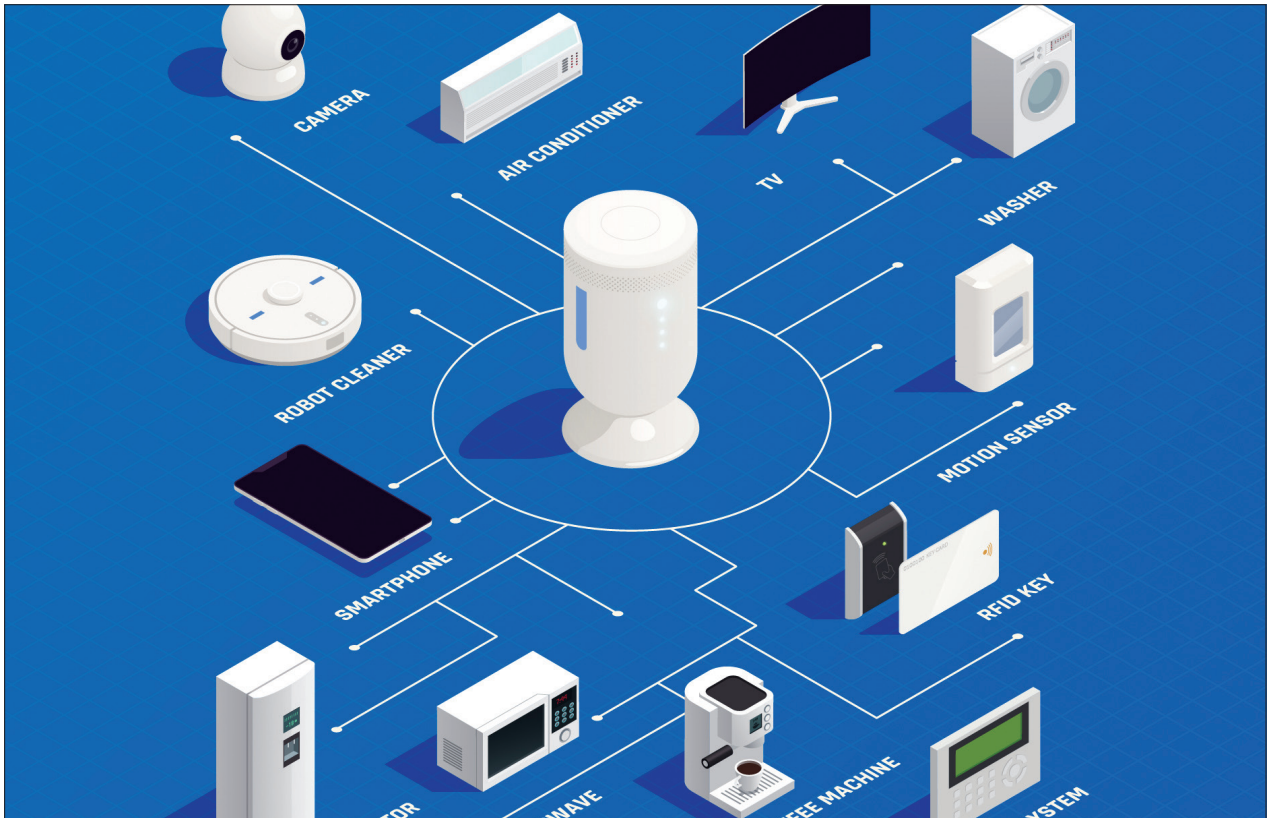




# Choose your ecosystem

Google, Alexa or Apple: Pick one brain

A smart home needs a “brain” – not because you love gadgets, but because somebody has to do three jobs:

1. Commission devices (pair them, name them, assign rooms)
2. Keep them reachable (especially Matter-over-Thread sensors)
3. Run automations (timers, triggers, conditions) without turning into a weekend hobby

In 2026, you can build a great smart home in four very different ways:

- **Google Home:** Android-friendly, family-friendly, improving local control

- **Amazon Alexa:** voice-first, broad device support, strong routines culture
- **Apple Home:** clean UX if your house is iPhone-heavy, strict requirements (good for reliability)
- **Home Assistant:** local-first, DIY-maximalist, the “I want control” option

This chapter helps you pick one primary ecosystem, set it up cleanly, and understand the three words that decide whether your home feels “instant” or “offline”: controller, bridge, and Thread border router.